

# 8 English Lines Nurses Use When an On-Call Doctor Says Wait

Eight phrases for the moment you need a colleague to act. These are not vocabulary words. They are the exact sentences a senior nurse uses, in the order they use them.

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## What you will be able to do

By the end of this page.

1. Identify which of two ways of raising a concern actually moves a doctor
2. Explain why “I have a bad feeling about her” loses to a named change
3. Produce all eight lines from the situation alone, without reading them
4. Evaluate an escalation you have just made and name what you would say differently next time

## BEFORE YOU START

**“I know what to say when an on-call doctor tells me my patient can wait.”**

Nobody sees this but you. It is stored on this device.

## Before you read anything

One shift, eight decisions. You have not been taught these yet — that is the point. Commit to an answer, then find out.



It is two in the morning. The patient in bed four is not the patient you took over at ten — her breathing has changed and she is harder to rouse. You have the on-call doctor on the phone, and he has now told you twice that it can wait for the morning round.

### 1. Which one does a senior professional say?

**Why the other one lands badly.** You are asking for one clear thing. A soft question gives the other person somewhere to put it down. When you say what you need, and when, there is nothing to postpone.

**SAY IT** I need you to come and see her now.

*I need you to come and see her now, please.*

## 2. Which one does a senior professional say?

**Why the other one lands badly.** A change over time is the thing a doctor acts on. Does not look good is your opinion, and it can be argued with. A change is information, and it cannot.

**SAY IT** **She has changed since I last saw her.**

*She has changed since I last saw her, about an hour ago.*

## 3. Which one does a senior professional say?

**Why the other one lands badly.** Concerned is a word that is heard in hospitals. A bad feeling is not. Saying and this is why forces you to give your reasons, and it tells the other person that reasons are coming.

**SAY IT** **I am concerned, and this is why.**

*I am concerned, and this is why. Three things have changed since lunchtime.*

## 4. Which one does a senior professional say?

**Why the other one lands badly.** While I wait for you assumes they are coming. You are not arguing about whether they will; you are asking what happens in the meantime. The question quietly settles the first one.

**SAY IT** **What would you like me to do while I wait for you?**

*What would you like me to do while I wait for you?*

## 5. Which one does a senior professional say?

**Why the other one lands badly.** This is a normal, expected step, and saying it in the normal words keeps it professional. It is not a threat and it is not a complaint. Everyone in the building knows what it means.

**SAY IT** I would like to escalate this.

*If you are not able to come, I would like to escalate this.*

## 6. Which one does a senior professional say?

**Why the other one lands badly.** Reading back catches the half of the message that did not arrive. It also puts what was agreed into the open, where both of you heard it, which matters later.

**SAY IT** Can I read this back to you?

*Can I read this back to you, so I have it right?*

## 7. Which one does a senior professional say?

**Why the other one lands badly.** Said flatly, this is simply what you are doing, and it is what you should be doing anyway. Just so you know turns the same sentence into a warning, and the conversation changes.

**SAY IT** I am documenting that I called at this time.

*I am documenting that I called at this time and what we agreed.*

## 8. Which one does a senior professional say?

**Why the other one lands badly.** You end well, and you book the next call before you need it. The second time you ring, you are continuing something, not starting an argument from the beginning.

**SAY IT** Thank you. I will call you back if anything changes.

*Thank you. I will call you back if anything changes.*

## The eight phrases

The same eight lines, now with the pronunciation and the reason each one works. Listen, then say each out loud.

1/8

**I need you to come and see her now.**

/aɪ niːd juː tuː kʌm ænd siː hɜː naʊ/

**MAKING THE ASK EXPLICIT**

**INSTEAD OF** Could you maybe come and have a look at some point?

**Why it works.** You are asking for one clear thing. A soft question gives the other person somewhere to put it down. When you say what you need, and when, there is nothing to postpone.

*I need you to come and see her now, please.*

Kailangan ko pong puntahan niyo siya ngayon.

2/8

## She has changed since I last saw her.

/ʃi: hæz 'tʃeɪndʒd sɪns aɪ læst sɔ: hɜ:/

REPORTING A CHANGE, NOT A NUMBER

**INSTEAD OF** She does not look very good.

**Why it works.** A change over time is the thing a doctor acts on. Does not look good is your opinion, and it can be argued with. A change is information, and it cannot.

*She has changed since I last saw her, about an hour ago.*

Nagbago po siya mula nang huli ko siyang makita.

3/8

## I am concerned, and this is why.

/aɪ æm kən'sɜ:nd ænd ðɪs ɪz waɪ/

NAMING THE WORRY, THEN EARNING IT

**INSTEAD OF** I have a bad feeling about her.

**Why it works.** Concerned is a word that is heard in hospitals. A bad feeling is not. Saying and this is why forces you to give your reasons, and it tells the other person that reasons are coming.

*I am concerned, and this is why. Three things have changed since lunchtime.*

Nag-aalala po ako, at ito ang dahilan.

4/8

## What would you like me to do while I wait for you?

/wɒt wʊd juː laɪk miː tuː duː waɪl aɪ weɪt fɔː juː/

KEEPING THE PLAN WITH YOU

**INSTEAD OF** So what should I do then?

**Why it works.** While I wait for you assumes they are coming. You are not arguing about whether they will; you are asking what happens in the meantime. The question quietly settles the first one.

*What would you like me to do while I wait for you?*

Ano po ang gusto ninyong gawin ko habang hinihintay ko kayo?

5/8

## I would like to escalate this.

/aɪ wʊd laɪk tuː ˈɛskəleɪt ðɪs/

THE FORMAL STEP, SAID CALMLY

**INSTEAD OF** Fine, I will just call someone else then.

**Why it works.** This is a normal, expected step, and saying it in the normal words keeps it professional. It is not a threat and it is not a complaint. Everyone in the building knows what it means.

*If you are not able to come, I would like to escalate this.*

Nais ko po itong iakyat sa mas mataas na antas.

6/8

## Can I read this back to you?

/kæn aɪ riːd ðɪs bæk tuː juː/

CHECKING YOU BOTH HEARD THE SAME THING

**INSTEAD OF** Okay, got it.

**Why it works.** Reading back catches the half of the message that did not arrive. It also puts what was agreed into the open, where both of you heard it, which matters later.

*Can I read this back to you, so I have it right?*

Maaari ko po bang ulitin ito sa inyo?

7/8

## I am documenting that I called at this time.

/aɪ æm ˈdɒkjʊmɛntɪŋ ðæt aɪ kɔːld æt ðɪs taɪm/

STATING THE RECORD, NOT THREATENING

**INSTEAD OF** I am writing this down, just so you know.

**Why it works.** Said flatly, this is simply what you are doing, and it is what you should be doing anyway. Just so you know turns the same sentence into a warning, and the conversation changes.

*I am documenting that I called at this time and what we agreed.*

Itatala ko po ang oras ng aking pagtawag.



8/8

## Thank you. I will call you back if anything changes.

/θæŋk ju: aɪ wɪl kɔ:l ju: bæk ɪf 'eniθɪŋ 'tʃeɪndʒɪz/

LEAVING THE DOOR OPEN

**INSTEAD OF** Okay, bye.

**Why it works.** You end well, and you book the next call before you need it. The second time you ring, you are continuing something, not starting an argument from the beginning.

*Thank you. I will call you back if anything changes.*

*Salamat po. Tatawag po ulit ako kung may magbago.*

## The steps

This is the sequence. It does not change.



### Change · Concern · Ask · Check

Four steps. If you remember nothing else tonight, remember that order. A colleague who hears a change, then a reason, then a clear ask, almost always moves.

## Now you produce it

Write your answer first, then compare. Retrieving the phrase from a situation is what moves it into the language you can actually use under pressure. There is more than one right answer.

**1. The doctor has said “let me know if she gets worse”. You need them now, not later.**

**I need you to come and see her now.**

You are asking for one clear thing. A soft question gives the other person somewhere to put it down. When you say what you need, and when, there is nothing to postpone.

**2. You are opening the call. Give the one fact that makes them listen.**

**She has changed since I last saw her.**

A change over time is the thing a doctor acts on. Does not look good is your opinion, and it can be argued with. A change is information, and it cannot.

**3. You have said you are worried and the doctor has not moved. Give them the reasons.**

**I am concerned, and this is why.**

Concerned is a word that is heard in hospitals. A bad feeling is not. Saying and this is why forces you to give your reasons, and it tells the other person that reasons are coming.

**4. The doctor is coming but will be twenty minutes. You are alone with her.**

**What would you like me to do while I wait for you?**

While I wait for you assumes they are coming. You are not arguing about whether they will; you are asking what happens in the meantime. The question quietly settles the first one.

**5. You have asked twice and been told to wait. This is the formal next step.**

**I would like to escalate this.**

This is a normal, expected step, and saying it in the normal words keeps it professional. It is not a threat and it is not a complaint. Everyone in the building knows what it means.

**6. The doctor has given you three instructions quickly and then paused.**

**Can I read this back to you?**

Reading back catches the half of the message that did not arrive. It also puts what was agreed into the open, where both of you heard it, which matters later.

**7.** The call is ending and you want the time and the decision on the record.

**I am documenting that I called at this time.**

Said flatly, this is simply what you are doing, and it is what you should be doing anyway. Just so you know turns the same sentence into a warning, and the conversation changes.

**8.** The doctor is coming. Close the call so that ringing again is easy.

**Thank you. I will call you back if anything changes.**

You end well, and you book the next call before you need it. The second time you ring, you are continuing something, not starting an argument from the beginning.

## Come back to this

Two situations, on the two days the research says matter. Say the phrase out loud before you look at the list again.

### **3**/day **Day 3**

*Three days ago you learned the four steps: change, concern, ask, check. New situation. A family member, not a colleague, is asking you why nothing is happening. Which of the four steps still applies, and which sentence would you open with?*

### **7**/day **Day 7**

*One week in. This is the one people get wrong. You are the senior now, and someone junior calls you sounding uncertain. Two phrases from this lesson still work here, from the other side of the call. Can you remember which?*

**NOW YOU HAVE WORKED THROUGH IT**

**"I know what to say when an on-call doctor tells me my patient can wait."**

## What you can do now

The same four, to check yourself against.

1. Identify which of two ways of raising a concern actually moves a doctor
2. Explain why “I have a bad feeling about her” loses to a named change
3. Produce all eight lines from the situation alone, without reading them
4. Evaluate an escalation you have just made and name what you would say differently next time

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